

Indian-Americans stay afloat is their tendency to save. While Indian-Americans may be weathering the storm better than most, there is a category which is deeply affected—the ones who were struggling even during the best of times. According to Seema Agnani, director of Chhaya Community Development Corporation (CDC), new research released by the organisation shows that South Asians, including Indians, number over 50 per cent of those at risk of foreclosure in many neighbourhoods. “What we are seeing is not a lot of job loss but loss of income, especially with people like cab drivers and construction workers who are dependent on

available at affordable cost, employers are likely to hire more American workers, instead of H-1B visa holders, especially in infotech.” However, he feels there would still be opportunities as the stimulus package is implemented, especially in the public construction segments. “The US still needs science and engineering students as in the past 15 years the number of such students graduating from American institutes has come down considerably,” Abraham says.

The future does seem brighter for people working in education, medicine and nursing—strong fields for the community—as the Obama Administration makes a new commitment to

Pandit, Citicorp CEO, has agreed to forgo his million-dollar salary for a compensation of one dollar a year in this new unnerving economy.

Then there's cabbie Kirpal Singh, a New York taxi driver who's worked here for 16 years. As people abandon taxis for bus and train, his fares and tips have decreased. He has found it hard to make the monthly mortgage and his home is currently in foreclosure. With a wife and two children to support, this is not the life he envisaged when he migrated. Everything has become expensive—the insurance, gas and repairs for his taxi, food and health insurance for the family. “*Sub kuchh barh gaya, hamara in-*



ROHINTON DADINA

Former managing director of Bear Stearns' International Debt Capital Markets Group

Persisted with his job hunt though many of his peers were planning to leave for India. Is now the managing director and senior credit officer at Minlam Asset Management LLC.

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tips and overtime wages,” she says.

South Asians working in the construction industry are seeing their jobs evaporate as construction is put on hold. As people downsize their dreams, the Dollar Stores, in which many Indian-Americans have invested, are doing better as people look to save a buck. So how are things going to change with Barack Obama's Administration? Thomas Abraham of GOPIO (Global Organisation of People of Indian Origin) finds the situation somber for H-1B visa holders: “Since a large pool of American citizens are

health and education. As Panagariya says, “Given the fact that there is a crisis, the stimulus is the only medicine. There's a lot of uncertainty as to when the spiralling down will be arrested, because we've just not seen anything like this, at least not in my lifetime.” The Indian-American community is probably less impacted by the downturn since the proportion of blue collar workers, who usually have less savings and resources, is lower than professionals within the community. Yet both the CEO and the cabbie are hurting, each in his own way. Vikram

come kam ho gaya,” he says. “*Agar business aisa hi raha, to wapas hi jayenge.*” A lot of people may not put this plan into action but in the fierce choke-hold of the scary economy, they are certainly thinking about it. For others, it's the Obama mantra—‘Persistence’ and the knowledge that tough times will pass. Says Dadina: “At the end of the day, this experience has made me stronger. Even for this job there were 300 applicants—and I got it, without any contacts. It's given me the confidence. I know now if I have to look for a job, I can do it.” ■